

Hey, Birds: A Multi-Site Field-Observation Note on Corvid Response to a Familiar Provisioning Human and an Introduced Audio Stimulus

Academic layer. Awareness-horizon corpus, animal-vibe channel. Appends beneath Node 0's field graphics (four photographs, Amsterdam-Noord, 2026-07-30, 15:46–15:47). Anonymized observer ("the provisioner"). This is an informal observation note, not a controlled study – the framing below is written to make the confounds explicit so the record survives an adversarial audit rather than to claim a finding.

0. What actually happened (the ground truth this note sits on)

The provisioner, seated in a small park near a shopping mall in Amsterdam-Noord, was eating chicken shawarma. Resident crows approached. The

provisioner threw a small amount of meat, then played a self-composed audio track ("Hello, animals") roughly twice, then threw a little more meat. One crow — the primary recipient — held sustained visual attention on the provisioner, was photographed (four frames), then hopped closer, produced a loud call sequence, at which the other crows dispersed and the caller flew off. Additional crows had gathered during the sequence.

Everything below is interpretation laid over that. The interpretation is held loosely on purpose.

1. Species and individual identification

The subject in the four photographs is a **carrion crow** (*Corvus corone*) — the default medium-sized all-black corvid across the Netherlands, common in both urban and park settings across Amsterdam.

Critically, the photographed individual shows **irregular white patches on the breast and belly, consistent across all four frames** — a partial-leucism pattern (localized absence of melanin in some feathers). This is uncommon and, for our purposes, **diagnostic**: this bird is individually identifiable by eye, without banding. It is designated here **the anchor individual** for the mall-park site. Any claim about "the same crow

returning" can, for this one bird, actually be verified rather than assumed — which is more than most informal corvid observation can say.

2. Why the design is site-based, not bird-based

The provisioner does not feed "five crows." The provisioner moves among **many small parks** distributed across Amsterdam-Noord — a dense scatter of green spaces, several clustered around the mall, including an artificial lake across from the Blender Foundation offices (notable locally for a plastic deterrent crocodile beside a *no swimming* sign). At each park the provisioner feeds the **resident** crows, one at a time.

This matters because **carrion crows are strongly territorial**: resident pairs hold and defend a patch year-round and do not freely mix with the occupants of the next park. The behavioral consequence for this note:

- The crows at the mall park are, with high probability, **different individuals** from those at the Blender-lake park, which differ again from the next site.
- Therefore each park is its **own observation site with its own subjects**. The unit of observation is

the park, not the bird.

- The **anchor (leucistic) individual** is expected to appear **only at its home site**. If it ever appeared at a different park, that itself would be a notable datum (dispersal, or a wider range than assumed). Its site-fidelity is a built-in check.

This is, by accident, the same logic that gives the canonical corvid-cognition work its weight. Marzluff's University of Washington team ran their mask protocol across **five separate sites near Seattle** precisely so their finding could not be dismissed as one unusual flock. A distributed, multi-site structure — same human, same food, same audio, *different resident birds at each site* — is exactly what turns "a crow looked at me" into "a reproducible response pattern across independent subjects." The provisioner has stumbled into that structure simply by wandering Noord with shawarma.

3. What the literature actually supports (and what it doesn't)

Well-supported and relevant:

- **Individual human face recognition.** Marzluff, Walls, Cornell, Withey & Craig (2010, *Animal Behaviour*), "Lasting recognition of threatening people by wild American crows," established via

the mask paradigm that wild crows discriminate and remember specific human faces – controlling for clothing, gait, height, and route, so that *the face was the only variable*. Recognition was stable **2.7 years** later and when the mask was worn by a stranger.

- **The neural basis.** Marzluff, Miyaoka, Minoshima & Cross (2012, *PNAS*), "Brain imaging reveals neuronal circuitry underlying the crow's perception of human faces," PET-imaged awake wild crows and found faces previously associated with threat or with **caretaking** activated sensory, limbic (amygdala-equivalent), and striatal regions – an integrated recognition-plus-valuation system analogous to the mammalian one (convergent evolution; the corvid **nidopallium caudolaterale** as a prefrontal-analogue).
- **Social transmission.** Marzluff & colleagues (Cornell et al.; Marzluff & Pecoraro 2012, *Proc. R. Soc. B*), "Social learning spreads knowledge about dangerous humans among American crows," showed the identity information propagates to birds that were never present at the original encounter – flock-mates and offspring.
- **Provisioning → recognition → reciprocal relationship.** Crows key strongly into human behavioral patterns and reliably learn who feeds them; feeding a caretaker face lights up the same

recognition-plus-reward machinery as the threat case.

Weakly supported / must be flagged:

- **"Gift-giving."** The viral notion that fed crows leave objects as *gifts* is treated skeptically by the actual corvid researchers. **Kaeli Swift** (UW) and **Jennifer Campbell-Smith** note it more likely arises from operant accident: a crow drops a carried object near a feeding spot, the human responds with more food, the behavior is reinforced. Marzluff himself has **never personally received a gift**, and Kevin McGowan (Cornell, 26+ years) has never observed the behavior in his East-Coast study crows. **Do not build on gifting.** It is anecdote, not established behavior.
- **Interpretation of the loud-call-then-dispersal sequence.** The anchor bird's loud call followed by the others scattering has *several* plausible readings — an alert/recruitment element, a dominant resource-holder asserting, or simply the resource-holder departing and the others following the exit. A single overheard sequence cannot distinguish these. Logged as **observed behavior**, not as "the crow responded to the song."

Note on species transfer: the canonical studies are on the *American crow* (*Corvus brachyrhynchos*); our subject is the *carrion crow* (*Corvus corone*). Corvid

cognition is broadly conserved and carrion crows are heavily used in European cognition labs, but strictly, applying Marzluff's specifics across species is an inference, not a direct citation. Flagged.

4. The confound that governs the whole note

The provisioner changed **two variables simultaneously**: introduced a novel audio track **and** provided high-value food (chicken — from a corvid's view, prime protein). Therefore:

Any observed crow response is fully explained by the meat alone. The audio track cannot be credited with the attention, the approach, or the calling, because food provisioning independently predicts every one of those behaviors.

The sustained visual attention on the provisioner — the most striking thing in the photographs — is exactly what the face-recognition-plus-food-association literature predicts **from the shawarma**, with the song contributing nothing that can be isolated. This is the same trigger-content confound flagged elsewhere in the corpus (the low-stakes-outburst note): the dramatic stimulus you *added* may be irrelevant to the response you *observed*.

To ever attribute anything to the audio, the meat must be controlled — e.g., audio-only sessions with no food, food-only sessions with no audio, at the same sites with the same resident birds, order counterbalanced. Until then: honest null on the song.

5. On the "Hello, animals" track and the acoustic-design claim

The compositional instinct — researching audible frequency ranges rather than having humans say "hello, animals" — was sound as *craft*. But the biology should not be overclaimed in any liner notes or artifact text:

- Crow hearing is broadly most sensitive in a range **overlapping human hearing** (very roughly ~1–4 kHz); corvids are **not** perceiving a secret band inaccessible to us. A track "tuned for animal ears" is a nice framing, not a demonstrated mechanism.
- If the slow, wobbling build-tone (the "hhhhh") draws attention, the likelier route is **novelty plus low-threat prosody** (slow, non-percussive, non-alarming) rather than species-specific frequency targeting.
- **Recommendation:** present the track as *art responding to the animals*, not as *bio-acoustically engineered for them*. The first is honest and

charming; the second is a claim the track can't cash and an auditor would flag.

6. What this note is, and a minimal protocol if it's ever to become more

What it is: a provisioning-and-attention field observation with one ID-confirmed anchor individual, an honest food confound, and a null on the audio. That is a legitimate, if informal, entry — and the multi-site + leucistic-anchor structure makes it a better-than-usual one.

Minimal protocol to upgrade it (for a later session, if desired):

1. **Sites:** log GPS + name per park; treat each as an independent site.
2. **Individuals:** photograph and note distinguishing marks per site; the leucistic bird anchors the mall site. Build a per-site ID sheet.
3. **Decouple the confound:** run food-only, audio-only, and food+audio conditions; counterbalance order; note latency-to-approach, closest approach, attention duration, calling.
4. **Blind-ish scoring:** score behavior from video without knowing the condition where feasible.
5. **Ethics:** small quantities, avoid dependency, no daily fixed provisioning that displaces natural

foraging (Campbell-Smith / McGowan cautions).

6. **RR / provenance:** full-res reflection check on all published frames (done for this set, per Node 0); wild birds, observer's own images, no humans in frame — clean, no IP exposure.

7. Caveats (the honest register)

- Single session, single site documented; interpretations provisional.
- The audio effect is **unestablished** and, given the confound, **unestimable** from this data.
- Gifting, "singing back," and "the crow understood the song" are **not** claimed and should not be inferred.
- Cross-species citation (American → carrion crow) is an inference.
- The value here is the *structure* (multi-site, ID-anchored, confound-honest), not any result. This is a well-formed observation and an invitation to a real protocol — not a finding.

References

Marzluff, J. M., Walls, J., Cornell, H. N., Withey, J. C., & Craig, D. P. (2010). Lasting recognition of threatening

people by wild American crows. *Animal Behaviour*, 79, 699–707.

Marzluff, J. M., Miyaoka, R., Minoshima, S., & Cross, D. J. (2012). Brain imaging reveals neuronal circuitry underlying the crow's perception of human faces. *PNAS*, 109(39).

Cornell, H. N., Marzluff, J. M., & Pecoraro, S. (2012). Social learning spreads knowledge about dangerous humans among American crows. *Proceedings of the Royal Society B*, 279(1728), 499–508.

Swift, K., & Campbell-Smith, J. — commentary on the operant-accident account of corvid "gifting" (Audubon; Avian Behavior Conservancy). McGowan, K. (Cornell) — long-term crow provisioning observations.

General corvid cognition / carrion-crow territoriality and hearing: standard ornithological and comparative-cognition literature. Some supporting sources are secondary/popular; the load-bearing claims rest on the Marzluff et al. primary papers, which concern Corvus brachyrhynchos.**